

In His Image – *Youth Edition*



Before you ever got a grade, a like, a follower, or a reputation, God already stamped you with worth. “Made in His image” means you’re built with dignity and purpose—and you’re meant to reflect God, not the pressure around you. These lessons will help you stop letting the world name you and start living from what God says is true.

Note: Whether you lead with these lessons or use them for the 5th week studies, these are built to build you and bless you.

In His Image (Youth Edition)

Lesson 1: Created with Intention

 **Background Text:** Gen 1; Ps 139:13–16; Mt 6:21; Jn 1:1–3; Col 1:15–20

Key Verse — Gen 1:27 (WEB)

“So God created man in his own image. In the image of God he created him; male and female he created them.”

Opening Prayer

Heavenly Father, thank You for the opportunity to learn more about You and to understand how deep, wide, and intentional Your love is for us. Help every reader know who they are and whose they are. We declare that hearts and minds are good grounds to receive truth, wisdom, and encouragement. Remove distractions and prepare the atmosphere to receive what You have for us. Amen.

Appetizer

One of the most powerful things about the Word of God is that no matter what season you're in—mentally, emotionally, spiritually, or just trying to figure life out—there is something in it that speaks directly to where you are.

These lessons are not coming from the place where something is “wrong” with you. They are an opportunity to check in and make sure you're as whole, as healed, and as grounded as you can be. With so much uncertainty in the world and so many different life experiences represented in one room, it's important to understand how those experiences shape how we see ourselves.

Some people grew up in single-parent homes. Some had both parents for a while. Some were raised by grandparents or other adults who stepped in. Sometimes having two people in a household wasn't healthy at all. Every situation is different, and we won't unpack all of them here—but like a buffet, there is something in each lesson for everyone.

This lesson can be done individually, but it often has the greatest impact in a group setting where people can learn, reflect, and encourage one another.

Main Course

Bite 1 — God's Original Intent, Gen 1:1; 1:26 (WEB)

“In the beginning God created the heavens and the earth.”

“Then God said, ‘Let's make man in our image, after our likeness.’”

God was strategic in how He created everything. There was order, intention, and purpose behind each step. When God reached humanity, He didn't rush. He spoke with intention and created us as a reflection of Himself.

That means you matter—regardless of what others have said, what circumstances you came from, or even what you've said about yourself. God didn't create humanity carelessly. He was intentional because He wanted relationship, connection, and reflection.

Question

What does it mean to you to know God intentionally created people—and you?

Bite 2 — The Image Was Distorted, Not Destroyed, Jn 1:1, 3; Col 1:17 (WEB)

“In the beginning was the Word...”

“All things were made through him.”

“He is before all things, and in him all things are held together.”

Originally, humanity was meant to live in connection with God—without the pressure, struggle, and confusion we experience today. Life changed after the fall, but God’s intention toward us didn’t.

Even now, Christ holds everything together. We still work, we still struggle, but we are not abandoned. Restoration is possible, and purpose still exists—even when life feels complicated.

Question

How does knowing Christ still holds everything together affect how you see your life right now?

Bite 3 — You Are God’s Treasure Matt 6:21 (WEB)

“For where your treasure is, there your heart will be also.”

Treasure isn’t just about money. It’s about effort, time, and sacrifice. When someone shows up for you—after a long day, a double shift, or when it costs them something—that’s a sign of care.

God didn’t give us something small. He gave us **everything** when He sent His Son. Jesus didn’t come only for the perfect or the put-together. He spent time with the broken, the overlooked, the confused, and the weary. Through His life and sacrifice, God showed how deeply He values humanity.

That kind of love shows us how God sees us—and how we can begin to see ourselves.

Question

What does God’s willingness to give His best reveal about how He values you?

Shared Truth

God does not make mistakes.

The image was damaged, not erased.

You are still deeply valued by God.

To-Go Box

- God created humanity with intention
 - Identity came before performance
 - Christ restores what was distorted
 - You matter deeply to God
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Activity

One truth from this lesson that encouraged me is _____.

One person I could share this encouragement with is _____.

Closing Reflection

This lesson is meant to remind you that life is worth living and that even in our imperfections, God sees purpose. You may not feel like you need this message today—but someone you know might. Carry the truth with you, and when the opportunity comes, share the hope and encouragement you've received.

Be blessed, encouraged, and strengthened.

Work Cited

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Lesson 2: Accepted and Loved

 **Background Text:** Rom 8:1; Eph 1:4–6; Lk 19:1–10; 1 Jn 3:1

 **Key Verse:** Rom 8:1 (WEB)

“There is therefore now no condemnation to those who are in Christ Jesus.”

Appetizer

Many people grow up believing acceptance must be earned. You’re welcomed when you behave right, perform well, or fit expectations. When you fall short, acceptance feels fragile—like it can disappear at any moment.

That mindset often follows people into their relationship with God. Some believe they need to clean themselves up, fix their past, or prove they’ve changed before they can truly belong. This lesson looks at how Jesus responds to someone who was judged, misunderstood, and reduced to a label—and what that teaches us about acceptance and love.

Main Course

Bite 1 — Seen Despite the Crowd, Luke 19:1–5 (WEB)

Jesus entered and was passing through Jericho. Zacchaeus was trying to see who Jesus was, but couldn’t because of the crowd, because he was short. He ran ahead, climbed up into a sycamore tree to see him... Jesus looked up and said to him, ‘Zacchaeus, hurry and come down, for today I must stay at your house.’

Zacchaeus wanted to see Jesus. His height and the crowd blocked his view, so he climbed the tree. The obstacle wasn't his desire—it was access. Jesus noticed him anyway.

This matters because Zacchaeus didn't call out to Jesus or explain himself. Jesus initiated the encounter. Before Zacchaeus spoke a word, Jesus saw him and invited Himself into his life.

Question

Have you ever wanted to be seen or understood but felt blocked by circumstances or people's opinions? How does Jesus' response to Zacchaeus speak to that?

Bite 2 — Grace Is Not Controlled by Opinion, Luke 19:6–7 (WEB)

“He hurried, came down, and received him joyfully.”

“When they saw it, they all murmured, saying, ‘He has gone in to stay with a sinner.’”

The crowd had opinions—and they weren't quiet about them. They reduced Zacchaeus to his occupation and his reputation. But Jesus didn't respond to the noise. He didn't explain Himself or backpedal.

Grace wasn't delayed by public opinion. Jesus chose relationship first, even when others disapproved. This shows us that God's acceptance isn't dependent on how people see you.

Question

How does knowing Jesus isn't swayed by other people's opinions change how you think about your own worth?

Bite 3 — More Than a Label, Luke 19:8–9 (WEB)

Zacchaeus stood and said to the Lord, ‘Behold, Lord, half of my goods I give to the poor.’

If I have wrongfully exacted anything from anyone, I restore four times as much.

Jesus said to him, ‘Today salvation has come to this house.’

Zacchaeus wasn’t deaf—he heard the murmurs. He knew how people saw him. His response wasn’t an attempt to earn Jesus’ visit; Jesus had already decided to come.

Zacchaeus was saying, *I am more than my occupation*. His generosity wasn’t for show. No one had been applauding his compassion before this moment, yet he continued to give. His actions revealed a heart already moving toward change.

Jesus affirmed what was already happening: acceptance first, transformation following.

Question

Why is it important to know that Zacchaeus didn’t give to earn acceptance, but to reveal who he already was becoming?

Shared Truth

Jesus sees beyond labels.

Grace comes before growth.

Your actions don’t define your worth—but they can reflect a changed heart.

To-Go Box

Jesus sees you beyond your reputation
Acceptance is not controlled by opinions
Grace creates space for real change

Activity — Circle & Reflect

Circle **two** statements that feel true for you right now:

- I feel seen by God
- I struggle with being labeled by others
- I want people to see my heart, not my past
- I'm learning to grow without pressure

Why did you choose those two?

Closing Reflection

Zacchaeus didn't have to prove himself to be accepted. Jesus saw his heart and affirmed what grace had already begun. This lesson invites you to believe that God meets you where you are and sees more in you than others ever have.

Work Cited

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Lesson 3: Restored and Whole

 **Background Text:** Ps 51:10; 2 Cor 5:17; Col 2:13–14; Isa 61:1–3

 **Key Verse:** 2 Cor 5:17 (WEB)

“If anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation. The old things have passed away. Behold, all things have become new.”

Appetizer

One of the biggest tricks of the enemy is convincing people they need to fix themselves before coming to Christ. The thought sounds reasonable: *“Let me get myself together first. Let me stop doing this. Let me clean this up.”*

But that mindset delays healing. Salvation isn’t the reward for being better—it’s the doorway to becoming whole. When Jesus said, *“It is finished,”* and the veil in the temple was torn, it symbolized the barrier between humanity and God being removed. What was lost in the Garden—connection and access—was restored through Christ.

God’s invitation is not *“fix yourself and come,”* but *“come and be restored.”*

Main Course

 **Bite 1 — God Restores from the Inside Psalm 51:10 (WEB)**

“Create in me a clean heart, O God. Renew a right spirit within me.”

God doesn't start restoration by covering things up—He starts by cleansing the heart. Trying to repair yourself before coming to God often leads to frustration and delay. Yielding allows God to do the work only He can do.

Restoration begins internally, not cosmetically.

Question

Why do you think people try to clean themselves up instead of coming to God as they are?

Bite 2 — New Means Cleansed, Not Covered, 2 Cor 5:17; Col 2:13–14 (WEB)

“If anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation.”

“You were dead... but he made you alive together with him, having forgiven us all our trespasses.”

Putting a Band-Aid on a dirty wound doesn't heal it—it hides it. Covering pain without cleansing it leads to infection. That's why Christ didn't come to patch us up; He came to make us new.

His blood doesn't just cover sin—it cleanses it. It disinfects what would otherwise slowly destroy us from the inside. Being made new means the old life is washed away, not hidden.

Question

Why is covering pain easier than allowing God to cleanse and heal it?

Bite 3 — Beauty Comes After the Fire Isaiah 61:1, 3 (WEB)

“He has sent me to bind up the brokenhearted...”

“To give them beauty for ashes...”

Jesus came intentionally and methodically. He knew people would carry heartbreak, disappointment, and loss. Binding the brokenhearted means He holds the pieces together.

Just like precious metals are refined through fire, restoration involves a process. Impurities burn away, and what remains is stronger, more valuable, and resilient. You may have gone through the fire—but you don’t have to smell like smoke.

Question

How does knowing God uses the process—not just the outcome—change how you view what you’ve been through?

Shared Truth

God doesn’t cover wounds—He cleanses them.

Restoration removes infection, not just appearance.

The fire refines, it doesn’t destroy.

To-Go Box

Restoration begins with surrender

Christ cleanses what we cannot

Your process has purpose

Word Study

Restore (Hebrew: *shûb*) — to return, bring back, renew

In Scripture, restoration means returning something to its intended state. God’s restoration isn’t cosmetic—it brings us back into alignment with how He designed us to live.

Activity — Word Scramble

Unscramble the words below (all come from today’s lesson):

1. **RTOESER** → _____

2. **NAELCSE** → _____

3. **NWE** → _____

4. **HTRAE** → _____

Which word stood out to you most, and why?

Closing Reflection

God isn’t waiting for you to be ready—He’s inviting you to be restored. What was broken can be cleansed, refined, and made whole again when we trust His process instead of trying to manage our own.

Work Cited

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